

Do not connect the tools. Connect through a file.

No plugin, no API, no installation beyond a folder. Everything here is typing into a chat box.

The problem, stated honestly

You now use three assistants. **None of them remembers yesterday, and none of them can see what the others said.** Every morning you explain your project again, three times.

And on a free plan there is no real integration to buy your way out of. The connectors, the agents, the shared memories — those are paid, and they tie your work to one company. There is a better answer, and it is older than all of them.

The shape: a file in the middle

the whole idea

ChatGPT ← paste → YOUR FILE ← paste → Gemini

↑

Claude

(the desk where most of the writing happens)

The file is the memory. The assistants are interchangeable workers. **You are the router** — and that is not a workaround, it is the part that makes the arrangement yours.

What a paid integration gives you	What a file gives you
It remembers, automatically	It remembers, and you can read exactly what it remembers
Inside one company's tools	In every tool, including the next one
Ends when the subscription ends	Yours permanently, in plain text
Needs your data connected to it	Nothing is connected. You choose what to paste.

That last row is the one that matters here. A connector gives an assistant your whole mailbox at once. A file gives it one paragraph you wrote on purpose. For work that includes material which must not leave the building, **only the second is available at all.**

Setting it up

ten minutes, once

1. **Make a folder** on your own computer. Call it anything.
2. **Make one text file per project** inside it, named after the project, ending **.md**. A .md file is a plain text file; Notepad or TextEdit opens it.
3. Put these four headings in it, and nothing else yet:

```
## What I decided
## Still open
## Sources I used
## The paragraph I paste into AI next time
```

4. **Optional:** install **Obsidian** from **obsidian.md/download** and point it at that folder. Obsidian does not move your files anywhere — it is a nicer window onto the same folder, with fast search and `[[links]]` between notes. One page covers **Windows, Mac, Linux, iPhone and Android**; the button names whichever machine you are on, so use *More platforms* for the others.

Obsidian is free — obsidian.md/download — for personal, commercial and non-profit use alike, and **with no sign-up required**. Its own licence page says so. The optional paid add-ons are **Sync** (a vault across your devices, end-to-end encrypted) and **Publish** (notes on the web). **Neither is needed for anything in this handout** — and if you keep the folder in your existing cloud drive, your phone can already read it without Sync. **What you would be buying is the convenience, not the capability — page 5 sets out exactly what Sync does, and what it does not.**

Two things that still apply. Installing software on a work computer is your IT department's decision, not ours. And none of this handout requires Obsidian — steps 1 to 3 are the system; step 4 is only comfort.



The two prompts that do all the work

One at the start of a conversation, one at the end. Same two in every tool.

Prompt 1 — OPEN: paste yesterday in

start of every session

Open a new conversation in whichever assistant fits today's job. Before anything else, paste the fourth heading of your file. That is all.

I am continuing a project. Here is where it stands.

[paste the paragraph under "The paragraph I paste into AI next time"]

Work from this. Use only figures I give you, and mark anything you are not certain of with [CHECK].

What that paragraph looks like

I am a researcher at a policy institute working on youth employment. I have a design memo with three rival hypotheses about why job search is long. I checked the national labour force table and found the gap between women's and men's unemployment rates widened from 1.3 to 2.5 points in one year. I have decided to pursue the withdrawal hypothesis. Open: whether that one year is a trend, and what the coefficients of variation are.

Three sentences: who you are, what the project is, what you decided. Then what is still open. Written for the machine, not for you.

Prompt 2 — CLOSE: let it write the note

end of every session — the important one

Before you close the conversation, ask for the note. This is the prompt that makes the whole arrangement work, because it removes the one step people never do.

```
#role my note-taker
#task write the closing note for my project file
#context this conversation
#constraints exactly four headings - What I decided / Still open /
  Sources I used / The paragraph I paste into AI next time; the last
  one written FOR an AI, three sentences, no jargon I did not use;
  wrap key concepts in [[double brackets]]; invent nothing
#format markdown I can paste straight into a note
```

Then: select it, copy it, paste it into your file. Fifteen seconds. Tomorrow you open a different assistant, paste the last heading, and it starts where you stopped.

The [[double brackets]] do nothing in ChatGPT, Claude or Gemini — they are for Obsidian, where they become links between your notes. Harmless everywhere else, and worth keeping so the note improves as your folder grows.

That is the loop

paste the paragraph → work → ask for the note → paste it back

Two prompts, three tools, one file. Nothing is connected to anything. Nothing can be switched off by a company, and nothing has to be re-explained.



Routing

The job	Usually best	Why
Reading a long document and questioning it	Claude	built for long-form reading and careful summaries
Drafting, rewriting, self-critique	Claude	the writing loop; holds a constraint like "do not add content"
Answers grounded ONLY in your own sources	Gemini Notebook	answers from what you uploaded, with citations to the passage
Anything inside Gmail, Docs or Drive	Gemini	it lives there
Quick exploration, images, spreadsheet help	ChatGPT	strong all-rounder, widely used, fast to try things in
Checking an important number	two of them	see below

The two-route move. For a number that will appear in something you sign: ask the same question in two different assistants, with the same wording, and compare. **Agreement raises trust; disagreement is a finding.** It costs two minutes and it is the only verification that needs no expertise.

What this cannot do — say it plainly

- Nothing syncs. The file does not update itself. If you skip prompt 2, that session is lost, and no tool will tell you.
- Nothing is automatic. You are the router, every time. That is the cost of it being free, portable and private.
- No assistant can see your folder. It sees only what you paste. That is a feature: it means you decide, per paragraph, what leaves your machine.
- The three-way sort still applies. Public — paste freely. Internal — anonymise first. Confidential or personal — never, in any of them, no matter how convenient the paragraph would be.

Start today, with one project

1. Make the folder and one .md file for the project you are actually working on.
 2. At the end of your next conversation — today — run prompt 2 and paste the result in.
 3. Tomorrow morning, open a different assistant from the one you used, and run prompt 1.
- Step 3 is the proof.** When yesterday's work continues in a tool that was never told about it, you will stop believing you need an integration. **You needed a file.**



What changes if you pay

Written against the loop on page 2, because that is the only comparison that helps you decide.

The same four steps, on each plan

Step of the loop	On a free plan	On a paid plan
1. Carry yesterday in	You paste the paragraph. Four seconds.	A Project or a memory may carry it for you — but you still have to check what it carried, and you cannot read it as plainly as your own file.
2. Give the standing instructions	You paste the skill page.	Stored once as a Skill, a Custom GPT or a Gem. Genuinely convenient.
3. Do the work	Daily limits; the strongest model capped or unavailable.	Higher limits, newest model, and agents that keep working while your laptop is shut.
4. Write the note back	You run prompt 2 and paste.	You run prompt 2 and paste.

Look at row four. It is identical on every plan, and it is the step the whole arrangement depends on. The one thing money cannot remove is the one thing that makes it work.

What paying actually buys

- Fewer keystrokes — the paste in step 2 disappears.
 - Room to work — you stop meeting a limit in the middle of a task.
 - The strongest model, for the jobs where the difference shows: long documents, careful reasoning, code.
 - Work while you are away — agents and scheduled runs. This is the only item on the list a free plan cannot imitate at all.
- Not on that list: better judgement, safer output, or a guarantee that a number is right. You buy time and capacity, never correctness.

What it does not buy — and one new duty it creates

- Not the file. Paid memory belongs to a company and ends with the subscription. Your folder does not.
 - Not the sort. Public / internal / confidential applies exactly as before.
 - Not the verification. A better model is confidently wrong less often — which makes it *harder* to catch, not easier.
- And the new duty. The paid features that impress most — connectors, agents reaching your mail and files — work by being given access to everything at once. Pasting is a decision per paragraph; connecting is one decision, made once, for all of it. That is an organisational choice, not a personal one.



What paying does not change

One worked example of a paid add-on, and the three signals that mean it is time.

A worked case: what "Sync" actually is

You write a note on your computer. You want it on your phone. Something has to copy the file. There are two ways, and they differ in one respect that matters here.

Obsidian Sync (\$4/user/month)	A cloud drive you already have
Copies the folder between your own devices automatically.	Copies it too — your folder simply sits inside OneDrive, iCloud or Google Drive.
End-to-end encrypted: their servers hold the file but cannot read it. Only your devices can.	The provider can read what is in it, exactly as with everything else you keep there.
Keeps version history, so a note you ruined this morning comes back. Costs money.	History depends on the drive. Costs nothing extra.

So the question is not "sync or no sync". It is who can read your notes on the way between your own devices — and for anything internal, your organisation has probably already answered that about its own drive. Ask them, not us.

When it is worth paying — three honest signals

- 1. You hit a usage limit in the middle of real work, more than once a week.
- 2. You run the same job for other people, and pasting the instructions is now the slow part.
- 3. You genuinely need something to run while you are asleep.

If none of the three is true yet, the free plan plus a folder is not a compromise — it is the correct answer, and it is what this entire workshop was built and delivered on.



Skills and Memories — two kinds of remembering

Asked in the room on the final day. The names differ by tool; the distinction does not.

The distinction, in one line

A skill is how you want the work done. A memory is what the tool knows about you. You write the skill, on purpose. The memory accumulates, from whatever you happened to say. Think of a restaurant. A skill is a recipe card you wrote — hand it to any cook and the same dish comes out, and you can give a copy to a colleague. A memory is the waiter who remembers you dislike chilli — convenient, personal, and not something you can hand to anyone.

The same two boxes, in each tool

names as of August 2026 — hunt, do not memorise

	ChatGPT	Claude	Gemini
Instructions you write the recipe card	Custom GPT, or a Project's instructions	Skills, or a Project's instructions	Gems
What accumulates about you the waiter	Memory	Memory	Saved info / personalisation features
Where to look	Settings → personalisation, or the sidebar near Projects. Availability differs by plan and moves every few months — check yours, write the date down.		

The pasted skill needs no box at all. Everything in the first row is a paid or plan-dependent container for the same page of text you can paste for free.

Three differences that matter in practice

- Ownership. A skill is a file: you can read it, correct it, delete it, and give it away. A memory is attached to your account — hard to audit, impossible to hand over.
- Contents. A skill contains only what you chose to write. A memory contains whatever you said — and if a past conversation included internal details, the memory may now hold them. For work under the three-way sort, that is a real consideration: memory makes past pastes persistent. Review what it has remembered, and delete what should not be there.
- Purpose. Same method every time, or a colleague doing it your way → skill. Tired of introducing yourself every morning → memory — or the file, which does the same job and answers to you.

One warning. Memory creates the feeling of being understood — and that is the exact moment people stop checking. A skill's instruction to *find one thing to fix* keeps working however well you are remembered, because it is a procedure, not a feeling.

And the file you built on page 1?

It is memory you control. The four headings and the handover paragraph are chosen by you, readable by you, portable to every tool on this page — and free. It has every property the paid boxes offer, except the convenience — which is the only part they are selling.

